



Historical Background of Muslim Nationalism, The Role of Sir Syed Ahmed Khan and Key Political Developments (1857-1900)

Introduction to Muslim Nationalism

Muslim Identity Post-1857:

- ▶ After the 1857 Revolt, Muslims faced severe repression from the British, leading to an identity crisis.
- ▶ Muslims began to see themselves as a distinct community with unique cultural and religious needs.

Importance of Nationalism:

- ▶ Shift from a Mughal-led empire to becoming a minority under British rule.
- ▶ Growing sense of needing to protect Islamic traditions and rights within the colonial framework.

Muslim nationalism tried to implement the manifestos like

- ▶ Rule of Law, socio-economic justice, equity and fair play.
- ▶ Equality of opportunity to all citizens irrespective of caste, sect, religion or region.
- ▶ Religious and Cultural tolerance.
- ▶ Respect for human dignity and rights.
- ▶ Protection of the rights and interests of non-Muslims and freedom to practice their beliefs and religions.

Sir Syed Ahmed Khan: A Pioneer of Muslim Nationalism

Early Life and Background:

- ▶ Born in 1817 in Delhi, belonging to a noble Mughal family.
- ▶ Witnessed the decline of the Mughal Empire and the aftermath of the 1857 Revolt.

Reaction to 1857 Revolt:

- ▶ Realized the need for reconciliation with the British and modernization of Muslim society.
- ▶ Wrote "Asar-us-Sanadid" and "The Causes of the Indian Revolt" to explain Muslim grievances and advocate for cooperation with the British

Aligarh Movement and Modern Education

Founding of MAO College (Aligarh):

- ▶ Established in 1875 to provide modern education to Muslims, combining Islamic teachings with Western knowledge.
- ▶ Aimed to produce a class of educated Muslims who could engage with the British on equal terms.

Promotion of English and Science:

- ▶ Emphasized the importance of learning English and scientific subjects to advance in the colonial administration.
- ▶ Urged Muslims to adopt a pragmatic approach to education rather than relying solely on traditional madrasas.

Muslim Leaders and the Aligarh Movement: A Path to Recovery After 1857

- ▶ In 1857, Muslim rule in India declined, and although both Muslims and Hindus fought in the War of Independence, the British unfairly blamed only the Muslims. As a result, Muslims faced severe persecution. Despite this, key figures like Justice Amir Ali Syed and the Aligarh movement emerged, helping Muslims reclaim their identity and political stance, preparing them to face future challenges.

The Two-Nation Theory and Muslim Nationalism

Concept of Two-Nation Theory:

- ▶ Sir Syed's idea that Hindus and Muslims were two distinct nations with their own customs, religion, and way of life.
- ▶ Laid the foundation for later demands for separate political representation and, eventually, a separate state.

Political Impact:

- ▶ Advocated for separate Muslim political identity within British India.
- ▶ Stressed the need for Muslims to remain loyal to the British for protection of their interests.

Social and Educational Reforms by Sir Syed

Rationalism and Reforms:

- ▶ Encouraged the reinterpretation of Islamic teachings in light of modern knowledge.
- ▶ Opposed the blind following of outdated traditions that hindered progress.

Establishment of Scientific Society:

- ▶ Founded in 1864 to translate Western works into Urdu, making scientific and political knowledge accessible to Muslims.

Major Political Developments (1857-1900)

The Aftermath of the 1857 Revolt:

- ▶ End of the Mughal Empire; establishment of British direct rule in India.
- ▶ Muslims were blamed for the revolt, leading to their marginalization in governance and administration.

Indian Councils Act 1861:

- ▶ Introduced limited participation of Indians in the legislative process, but Muslims were underrepresented.
- ▶ Highlighted the need for Muslims to seek greater political involvement.

Emergence of Indian National Congress (1885)

Formation of INC (Indian National Congress):

- ▶ Established by A.O. Hume as a platform for Indian voices, predominantly Hindu-dominated.
- ▶ Muslims felt alienated due to the INC's focus on issues that often did not align with their interests.

Muslim Response:

- ▶ Growing sense of the need for separate political representation to safeguard Muslim interests

The Simla Deputation (1906)

Background:

- ▶ Muslim leaders, led by Aga Khan, met Viceroy Lord Minto in Simla to demand separate electorates for Muslims.
- ▶ Argued that Muslims were a minority and needed special provisions to protect their rights.

Significance:

- ▶ Marked the first formal demand for separate Muslim political representation.
- ▶ Laid the groundwork for the formation of the All-India Muslim League in 1906.

Formation of the Muslim League in Dhaka: December 30, 1906

- ▶ On December 30, 1906, the All India Muslim League was established in Dhaka, following the success of the Simla Deputation. Muslim leaders, aiming for a permanent political platform, gathered after the Mohammedan Educational Conference to form the league. The meeting was chaired by Wiqar-ul-Mulk, with Nawab Salimullah proposing the idea, and Hakim Ajmal Khan and Maulana Zafar Ali Khan seconding it. The league's constitution was approved at the Karachi session in December 1907, and Agha Khan was elected its president at the Aligarh session in March 1908.

London Branch of the Muslim League: May 1908

- ▶ In May 1908, Justice Amir Ali Syed established a London branch of the Muslim League to address misunderstandings and conspiracies against Muslims by Hindus.

Goals:

- ▶ **Protect and Promote:** Safeguard and advance the political rights and interests of Muslims.
- ▶ **Cooperate:** Work with other communities while prioritizing Muslim interests.
- ▶ **Foster Loyalty:** Encourage a sense of loyalty among Muslims towards the government.

Change in the Goals of the Muslim League: 1913

- ▶ By 1913, events such as the annulment of the Partition of Bengal, Western aggression against Muslim countries, and the demolition of the mosque in Kawnpur had eroded Muslim confidence in the British. As a result, the Muslim League revised its goals:
- ▶ **Self-Government:** Seek self-government under the British Crown, considering India's unique conditions.
- ▶ **Cooperation:** Build good relations with other communities and work with any party sharing similar goals.

This shift in policy brought the Muslim League and Congress closer together, fostering cooperation between Hindus and Muslims. The Quaid-i-Azam played a crucial role in this process by joining the Muslim League in 1913.

Lucknow Pact: 1916

- ▶ The Lucknow Pact, achieved through the efforts of M. A. Jinnah, marked a significant moment of Hindu-Muslim unity. In December 1915, the Muslim League and Congress met separately in Bombay and formed committees to propose constitutional changes.
- ▶ **Role of Quaid-i-Azam:** Jinnah played a key role in bridging the gap between Hindus and Muslims while advocating for Muslim rights. The pact was finalized at a joint meeting in Lucknow in 1916, leading to the approval of the following constitutional proposals:
- ▶ **One-Third Representation:** Muslims would hold one-third of the seats in the Imperial Legislative Council.
- ▶ **Separate Electorate:** Maintaining separate electorates for Muslims.
- ▶ **Executive Council:** Half of the Executive Council members would be elected by the Imperial Legislative Council.
- ▶ **Army Ranks:** Indian officers would be commissioned into the army.
- ▶ **Provincial Councils:** Expansion of Provincial Legislative Councils.
- ▶ **Governor's Executive Council:** Half of the members would be elected by the Provincial Legislative Council.
- ▶ **Minority Representation:** Ensuring weightage for minorities in provinces.

Gains from the Muslim Point of View:

- ▶ **Separate Electorate:** Muslims could vote in separate elections to choose their representatives, ensuring their interests were specifically addressed.
- ▶ **One-Third Representation:** Muslims were guaranteed one-third of the seats in the Central Legislature, giving them a significant voice in national decisions.
- ▶ **Veto Power:** Any bill proposed by the government could be blocked if three-fourths of the Muslim members opposed it, giving Muslims a strong say in legislative matters.

Constitutional Developments Impacting Muslims

Indian Councils Act 1892:

- ▶ Expanded the role of Indians in legislative councils, but the electoral process was indirect and limited.
- ▶ Muslims continued to push for greater representation and separate electorates.

Partition of Bengal (1905):

- ▶ Initially supported by Muslims as it created a Muslim-majority province, but later reversed due to Hindu opposition.
- ▶ Heightened Muslim fears of Hindu domination and reinforced the demand for separate representation.

British Government Announcement (August 20, 1917):

The British government, represented by Secretary of State Montagu, made the following promises:

- ▶ **Greater Indian Involvement:** Indians would have more roles and responsibilities in all branches of the government, moving towards greater self-governance.
- ▶ **Responsible Government:** The government would become more accountable to Indian people, with Indian representatives playing a larger role in decision-making.
- ▶ **Commissioned Ranks:** Indians would be allowed to hold higher, commissioned ranks in the military, which had previously been reserved for British officers.
- ▶ In essence, these changes aimed to give Muslims a better position in the political system and promised more Indian involvement in governance.

Conclusion

Summary of Key Points:

- ▶ Muslim nationalism emerged as a response to political, social, and educational challenges post-1857.
- ▶ Sir Syed Ahmed Khan played a crucial role in promoting Muslim identity, modern education, and political activism.
- ▶ Major political developments between 1857 and 1900 laid the foundation for future Muslim demands for a separate state.